



Bipolar disorder

Formerly known as manic depression, bipolar disorder is a mental condition marked by alternating periods of exaggerated elation and depression, in which a person's mood swings suddenly from one extreme to another.

Bipolar mood swings vary enormously, and individuals with the disorder may also have “normal” moods. The patterns are not always the same, however; some people may experience rapid cycling from high to low, or a kind of mixed state.

Treating bipolar disorder involves reducing the severity and number of opposing episodes to give sufferers as normal a life as possible. Medicines such as mood stabilizers, a recognition of triggers and warning signs, psychological treatment such as cognitive behavioral therapy, and lifestyle advice are all used to treat bipolar patients. When effective, episodes usually improve within months.

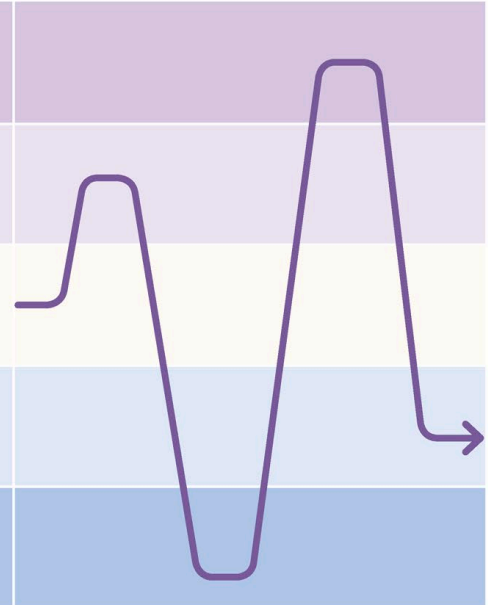
Mania Mania symptoms include euphoria, rapid speech, short attention span, loss of sleep or appetite, and occasionally psychosis.

Hypomania This is a milder version of mania that lasts a few days, often with agitation and reckless social or financial behavior.

Balanced mood Euthymia is the term used to describe the relatively stable mood state where a person is neither manic nor depressed.

Mild depression Symptoms may include feeling sad, hopeless, or irritable; a lack of energy; difficulty concentrating; and feelings of guilt.

Depression Emotionally painful, this phase may be marked by flat mood, misuse of drugs and alcohol, self-harm, and suicidal thoughts.



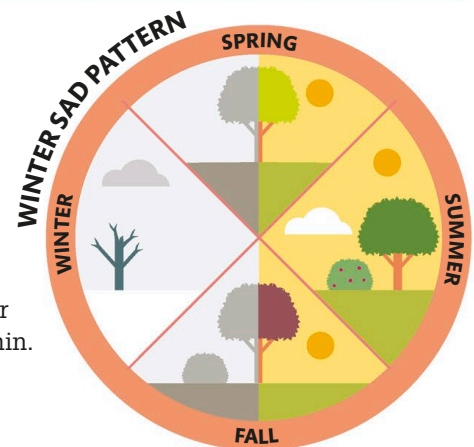
Seasonal affective disorder

Seasonal affective disorder, or SAD, is a depression that comes and goes in a seasonal pattern. It is sometimes known as “winter depression,” as that is when symptoms are usually more severe.

The exact cause of SAD is not fully understood, but for those who suffer from winter SAD—where the onset of cold weather triggers symptoms—it is often linked to reduced exposure to sunlight, which limits the functioning of the hypothalamus. This is the part of the brain that controls mood. Some people, however, experience symptoms when warmer weather begins—known as summer SAD.

Other possible causes include a malfunctioning “body clock,” which regulates sleep patterns, or abnormally high levels of melatonin.

Symptoms include depression, a loss of pleasure in everyday activities, irritability, feelings of despair, guilt, or worthlessness, and a lack of energy. Tracking symptoms in a diary, exercise, light therapy, and support groups are some self-help methods used by sufferers.



Winter pattern Symptoms begin at the change of fall to winter, marked by low energy levels and poor mood.

Summer pattern Symptoms reduce or disappear in early spring. There is a return of energy and normal sleep patterns.